after being held responsible for India's lack of preparedness for the 1962 War. In the midst of the crisis, Nehru himself temporarily took over the defence portfolio. The Soviets, who had provided India with defence equipment long before the war, found themselves in a severe dilemma. According to Mohan Ram, an Indian journalist and a specialist on Sino-Indian relations, the Soviets had begged the Chinese to stop their military operations and offered mediation, for which India was ready. 'They tried hard to prevent India from looking to the United States and Britain. Thus, years of striving for India's neutrality went to waste and capitalists were supplying arms to India thanks to the Chinese aggression.'[56]

Another disclosure, according to Ram, was the Soviet concern over the ouster of Menon from the Indian government. Ram quotes a rejoinder from the Soviets saying that 'Chinese aggression also had the consequences that we lost one of our most faithful friends among the Indian leaders, and that because he relied on our help'.[57]

Khrushchev had remained neutral during the skirmishes along the Sino-Indian border in 1959, which had angered the Chinese. As tension between India and China was brewing in 1962, the Chinese called upon the leaders of the Soviet Union to 'denounce the Indian bourgeoisie as a lackey of imperialism'—which they refused to do.[58] Instead, on 12 December, when the war was over, Khrushchev came out in support of India, saying 'we absolutely disallow the thought India wanted to start war with China'.[59] Thus, China managed to force India to seek help from the United States, and also put the Soviet Union in the same anti-Chinese camp. It was a masterstroke that placed China as the leader of the Third World.

According to MacFarquhar, 'Nehru's appeal for Western aid in his hour of need dented, if it did not destroy, India's image as a non-aligned nation, thus diminishing its status both in the Communist bloc and the Third World…Beijing had also demonstrated to a deaf Moscow the unwisdom of choosing India over China as an ally.' But, most importantly, MacFarquhar states that rising tension with India even in early and mid-1962, which eventually led to outbreak of hostilities in October, 'had signalled to its erstwhile communist partner that the banner of militant Marxism-Leninism had once more been unfurled over Beijing'.[60] The year of 1962 saw China, with Mao back at the helm, successfully challenging both India and the